

ISSUE TWO · FROM THE DESK OF SARAH BONANNO

A great college essay is *about* something.

02

Making sure your main point makes it onto the page.

When I applied to college, I wrote about a game. Every day at recess, my best friend and I played the same one: we were two orphans breaking out of an orphanage — a little bit *Annie*, mostly our own invention — and every afternoon we built that whole world back up from scratch.

I didn't write about it to prove I was imaginative. I wrote about it because that game was the truest thing I could point to about who I am: that I build worlds, that creativity and imagination are how I make sense of things — and that building worlds was exactly what I wanted to keep doing once I got to college.

Your admissions officer should be able to write your main point in one sentence in their notes — they shouldn't have to guess.

That essay worked because of one quiet thing: it was *about* something. An admissions reader gets through thousands of essays a season, and the ones that blur together are the résumé in paragraph form and the beautifully-written piece you finish without being able to say what it was *about*. Here's how I get students to the other kind.

THE METHOD *five moves from blank page to a point*

01 Start with one real moment

Not a theme — a moment. One specific scene you can still picture. The more specific it is, the easier everything after this gets.

02 Ask what it shows about you

Sit with the moment and ask why it stuck. What does it reveal that a list of your accomplishments never could? That's your main point.

03 Skip the lesson you think they want

"I learned that hard work pays off" is the line everyone reaches for because it sounds safe. Cross it out. The honest version is always the better essay.

04 Show it before you tell it

Put the reader in the moment first. Then, and only then, tell them what it meant to you. The order matters.

05 Answer "so what?"

Say why this matters — not just to you, but to a reader who's never met you. Your reader looks for that in your opening and again at your close.

THE TEST OF A REAL POINT

Only you could write it

Built from the details of your one moment, not a theme anyone could borrow.

You actually mean it

The honest thing the moment taught you, not the lesson you think admissions wants to hear.

It matters beyond the moment

It points past the story to who you are.

That recess game checked all three — only I could've written it, I meant every word, and it pointed straight at who I was becoming.